Financing power: Climate, capital and control

The Government–Industry Data Exchange Program (GIDEP) report warns that Africa receives less than three per cent of global climate finance. The climate finance gap is not merely a fiscal shortfall; it is a profound imbalance of political power. For Africa to access the capital required for a green industrial revolution, it must move beyond fragmented, nation-by-nation appeals. Climate finance must be redesigned as mission finance that links green funding to productive transformation, not external compliance. This could be achieved through a unified front through a continental Green Industrial Finance Facility. Funded by the continent's development banks, it could ensure that Africa does not plead for inclusion in existing mechanisms, but help redesign fit-for-purpose mechanisms. However, the proposed facility should be designed precisely to counter this, ensuring that green partnerships build domestic industrial capacity and climate resilience, aligning global capital with continental priorities rather than perpetuating old dependencies. A continental Green Industrial Finance Facility could channel green bonds into solar textile zones, electric-mobility clusters, and renewable manufacturing corridors.

Strategic reciprocity: A new social contract

Industrial policy is a social contract between the state and society. Thus, inclusive development depends on negotiated cooperation, where firms grow through state support, and states gain legitimacy through jobs and learning. I call this strategic reciprocity, where states invest in industries that promise shared value, and firms reciprocate through innovation, training, and ethical reinvestment.

This principle extends beyond economics; it is a justice issue. Africa's youth, women, and informal entrepreneurs must see themselves in the industrial story. Otherwise, transformation will be efficient but empty.

The second liberation: Governing for learning

Industrial policy is nationcraft. Africa's second liberation will be won in ministries, laboratories, and boardrooms where production and purpose converge. Governance is Africa's next comparative advantage, and coordination is its frontier. Industrial futures will be determined in the coordination space—where governance, trade, finance, and technology converge. This demands political will, policy coherence, and inclusive partnerships across sectors and borders.

As the world turns its attention to Africa through forums like the G20, the continent must present a vision that is compelling and unequivocal: industrial policy grounded in strategic reciprocity, adaptive learning, and unyielding sovereignty. This is how immense potential becomes self-determined, green, and digitally enabled industrial growth.

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